The Badal faction will have to compete with long-time pro-Khalistan voice and SAD (Amritsar) chief Simranjit Singh Mann, who has been contesting the seat in every poll since winning it in 1999. The fact that both Deep Sidhu and Moosewala used to support his politics won't harm the 77-year-old Mann. A former IPS officer, Mann was initially pushing for a joint 'panthic' (devout Sikh) candidate and Badal had agreed. But they couldn't agree over the name. Badal, who has been desperate for SAD's political revival since its near-decimation in the assembly polls earlier this year, rooted for Kamaldeep Kaur after Akal Takht jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh's appeal for a candidate from a *bandi* Sikh family. He tried to persuade Mann to withdraw from the contest, but failed.

THE AKALI DAL HAS FIELDED KAMALDEEP KAUR, SISTER OF BABBAR KHALSA MILITANT RAJOANA, BEANT SINGH'S ASSASSIN

On its part, the AAP continues to rely on Mann's popularity in this constituency and has fielded the low-profile Gurmel Singh, an environmentalist and sarpanch of Ghrachon village. Before his name came up, the constituency was flooded with posters of CM Mann's sister Manpreet Kaur, but the AAP leadership in Delhi chose Gurmel instead. In his campaign, Gurmel talks about the work done by the Mann government to curb corruption and the mafia, but gets dodgy when the local media and people ask about the deteriorating law-and-order situation in the state.

In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, Sangrur was the only constituency in Punjab that elected an MP from the AAP. Voters in Sangrur didn't abandon the party even when it lost everywhere else in the country, including stronghold Delhi. Historically, Sangrur has always voted for change—before Bhagwant Mann, who won the seat in 2014 and 2019, former Akali Dal CM Surjit Singh Barnala was the only other leader to have won back-to-back polls here. But what gives AAP much confidence about repeating its 2019 win is the party's performance in the assembly polls in March where it swept all nine segments in the Sangrur Lok Sabha constituency with more than 50 per cent votes.

Claiming that the state government is using its might to help Gurmel, his opponents say that voters will punish him for "Mann's bad governance". The Congress has fielded Dalvir Singh Khangura alias Goldy, who had contested against Mann in the assembly polls from Dhuri. The grand old party was keen to give the ticket to Moosewala. "Now we are contesting to seek justice for him," says Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, Punjab PCC chief. Rahul Gandhi, who visited Moosewala's family after his murder, accused the Mann government of failing to uphold law and order.

The BJP, too, is taking potshots at the AAP government's failures on the law-and-order front. The party has fielded Kewal Singh Dhillon, who had contested for the Congress from Sangrur in 2019 and finished second. He is being assisted by other turncoats such as former PCC chief Sunil Jakhar in reaching out to the villages, while former minister Rana Gurmit Singh Sodhi has been made in-charge of the seat. With runners-up of the last four polls—Dhillon, Arvind Khanna, Sukhdev Dhindsa and Parminder Dhindsa—on its side, the BJP, too, is hoping to do well. The bypoll will show whether Sangrur stands firm with the AAP or chooses to give another party a chance. ■



NILOTPAL BARUAH

Over a decade after Karnataka's iron-ore mining fiasco, the roadmap to normalcy in the Bellary region crossed a decisive milestone last month—on May 20, the Supreme Court, which has been monitoring matters since 2011, lifted the decade-old ban on export of ore. That trail of rust-red dust left by ore-laden trucks en route to the ports will become a familiar sight in Karnataka again.

Bellary's infamy from rampant illegal mining had peaked in 2011 when the apex court banned all mining and embarked on the process of setting things right. The mines, all 166 of them, were categorised into three groups based on how kosher their operations were—the ones in Category A and B were allowed to resume activities provided they followed the SC's conditions; Category C mines, guilty of the maximum encroachments, were cancelled and put up for auction again. Both the stockpiles of illegally mined ore and freshly-mined stock, however, could only be sold to buyers within the state via e-auctions. From this, 10-25 per cent of the sale price was set aside.

That's the bigger, climactic event